series of messages from friends and well-wishers. As the same aircraft was continuing on to Dehradun, I told Anjali that I was going to sit with the captain in the cockpit while the new passengers boarded, as I didn't feel like speaking to anyone for the time being.

I also asked Anjali if she would gently break the news of my decision to Arjun, as I was concerned about how he would take it. Anjali later told me that she would never forget his reaction. He said that he was sure I still had a lot of cricket left in me and there was no reason for me to retire, but when Anjali explained to him that the decision was final, he turned his face away and leaned his head on the window and a tear drop rolled down his cheek. Anjali and I both got very emotional when she told me this. Sara, being a little older, said that she would miss seeing me play but had full faith in my decision. My children were growing up fast and it mattered to me that they were both by my side at a time like this. Whenever they are with me, it always makes a huge difference to my well-being.

Mussoorie was a timely break. There was no one there except family and a few very close friends and I had some time to myself and a chance to think about my future. The media and fans allowed me the privacy to do so and while I still followed Mumbai's progress in the Ranji Trophy, I also managed to switch off from cricket for a while. I played table tennis, went for long walks and relaxed in the evenings, and managed to get my sense of optimism back. When I started to feel the urge to resume training, I knew it was time to return to Mumbai.

Australia in India, February–March 2013

I used to reach the Wankhede Stadium for training at around seven every morning, and for a while I would be completely alone in the stadium. On some days trainer Rahul Patwardhan would join me. The early-morning dew coated the lush green outfield and I could feel the dampness on my feet as I ran, leaving a trail behind me. When I looked up at the empty galleries I knew that this was where I belonged. This was my refuge.

I would jog and then run for a while and do my fitness drills before the groundsmen arrived. The Mumbai team would normally turn up around 8.30 a.m., by which time I would be in the dressing room taking a breather. Then I would train with my team-mates, doing my regular net sessions to prepare for the Ranji Trophy. In all my years of playing